

# The Noble Perfection of Wisdom Called Kauśika

Ārya Kauśika Prajñāpāramitā Nāma · Toh 19 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་ཤེས་རབ་ཀྱི་ཕྱི་རོལ་ཏུ་ཕྱུག་པ་ཀའི་གྲོ་མེ་བ་བྱ

Toh 19 in the Kangyur is a sūtra known in English as the Noble Perfection of Wisdom Called Kauśika, in Sanskrit as the Ārya Kauśika Prajñāpāramitā, and in Tibetan as Phags pa shes rab kyi pha rol tu phyin pa kau shi ka. It belongs to the Perfection of Wisdom class of texts and presents the Buddha teaching Śakra, lord of the gods — whose epithet Kauśika gives the text its name — on the nature of the Perfection of Wisdom as beyond duality, signs, and all conceptual elaboration. The setting is Vulture Peak Mountain near Rājagṛha, where the Buddha addresses a vast assembly of monks and bodhisattvas, and the text unfolds as a direct discourse on the ineffable character of wisdom that transcends taking up or casting aside. As a relatively concise Prajñāpāramitā sūtra, it sits within the broader collection of Perfection of Wisdom scriptures in the Kangyur.

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Thus it is praised. The noble Perfection of Wisdom in Fifty Lines is complete.

In the language of India: Ārya Kauśika Prajñāpāramitā Nāma. In the Tibetan language: The Noble Perfection of Wisdom Called Kauśika.

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling on Vulture Peak Mountain near Rājagṛha, together with a great Saṅgha of monks and with many hundreds of thousands of bodhisattvas, all of them youthful.

Then the Blessed One spoke to Śakra, lord of the gods, known as Kauśika:

Kauśika, this is the meaning of the Perfection of Wisdom. The Perfection of Wisdom is not to be regarded as dual, nor as non-dual. It is not marked by signs, nor is it without signs. It is neither to be taken up nor cast aside. It is neither added to nor without addition. It is neither defiled nor free from defilement. It is neither purified nor unpurified. It is neither abandoned nor not abandoned. It is neither a place of abiding nor without a place of abiding. It is neither to be applied nor unapplied. It is neither connected nor unconnected. It is neither a condition nor without conditions. It is neither a phenomenon nor not a phenomenon. It is neither suchness nor the absence of suchness. It is neither the ultimate limit nor the absence of the ultimate limit.

Kauśika, likewise the meaning of the Perfection of Wisdom is this. Because all phenomena are equal, the Perfection of Wisdom is equal. Because all phenomena are profound, the Perfection of Wisdom is profound. Because all phenomena are solitary and apart, the Perfection of Wisdom is solitary and apart. Because all phenomena are without wavering, the Perfection of Wisdom is without wavering. Because all phenomena are without conceit, the Perfection of Wisdom is without conceit. Because all phenomena are without fear, the Perfection of Wisdom is without fear. Because all phenomena are without shame or embarrassment, the Perfection of Wisdom is without shame or embarrassment. Because all phenomena have one taste, the Perfection of Wisdom has one taste. Because all phenomena are without arising, the Perfection of Wisdom is without arising. Because all phenomena are without cessation, the Perfection of Wisdom is without cessation. Because all phenomena are like space, the Perfection of Wisdom is like space. Because form is without limit, the Perfection of Wisdom is without limit. Likewise, because feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are without limit, the Perfection of Wisdom is without limit. Because the earth element is without limit, the Perfection of Wisdom is without limit. Likewise, because the water element, the fire element, the wind element, the space element, and the consciousness element are without limit, the Perfection of Wisdom is without limit. Because Mount Meru is without limit, the Perfection of Wisdom is without limit. Because the ocean is without limit, the Perfection of Wisdom is without limit. Because it is equal to the vajra, the Perfection of Wisdom is equal. Because all phenomena are undivided, the Perfection of Wisdom is undivided. Because the essential nature of all phenomena is not to be apprehended as an object, the essential nature of the Perfection of Wisdom is not to be apprehended as an object. Because all phenomena are equal in being beyond exclusion, the Perfection of Wisdom is equal beyond exclusion. Because all phenomena are without agency, the Perfection of Wisdom is without agency.

Because all phenomena are inconceivable, the Perfection of Wisdom is inconceivable. In the same way, the Perfection of Generosity, the Perfection of Moral Discipline, the Perfection of Patience, the Perfection of Diligence, the Perfection of Meditative Concentration, the Perfection of Wisdom, the Perfection of Skillful Means, the Perfection of Aspiration, the Perfection of Power, and the Perfection of Gnosis — because all three spheres are perfectly pure, the Perfection of Wisdom is without limit.

What is called the Perfection of Wisdom is this: the eighteen emptinesses, which are as follows. The emptiness of the inner. The emptiness of the outer. The emptiness of the outer and inner. The emptiness of emptiness. The great emptiness. The emptiness of the ultimate. The emptiness of the conditioned. The emptiness of the unconditioned. The emptiness that transcends all extremes. The emptiness of the beginningless and endless. The emptiness of the non-discarded. The emptiness of intrinsic nature. The emptiness of all phenomena. The emptiness of individual characteristics. The emptiness of the unobjective. The emptiness of non-existence. The emptiness of essential nature. The emptiness of the essential nature of non-existence. In brief, this emptiness is what is called the Perfection of Wisdom.

Like a star, a visual aberration, a lamp,  
an illusion, dew-drops, a water bubble,  
a dream, a flash of lightning, a cloud —  
so should all conditioned things be seen.

Homage to the Blessed Noble Perfection of Wisdom.

Om dhīḥ hrīḥ śrī śruti smṛti mati gati vijaye svāhā.

Without cessation and without arising,  
without annihilation and without permanence,  
not of distinct meaning and not of single meaning,  
without coming and without going,  
peaceful through the stilling of conceptual elaboration —  
to the one who teaches dependent origination,  
who is a fully awakened buddha,  
the supreme speaker, I bow down.

Having thus declared these words, the Blessed One — and the venerable Śāradvatīputra, and Śakra (Indra, lord of the gods), and those monks, and those bodhisattvas, and the gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas together with the world — rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had taught.

The noble Perfection of Wis—

## Translator's Notes

- The phrase rendered "without shame or embarrassment" translates a term that in other contexts means "without modesty" in a neutral or positive sense of fearless confidence rather than shamelessness. Here, in a series of qualities praising the Perfection of Wisdom, it indicates freedom from the constrictive mental factor of timidity or self-consciousness, not moral shamelessness.

The phrase rendered "equal beyond exclusion" or "equal in being beyond exclusion" translates a compound meaning equanimity or equality in which nothing is set aside or eliminated, emphasizing the all-inclusive, non-rejecting character of the Perfection of Wisdom.

The opening line "Thus it is praised" and the colophon "The noble Perfection of Wisdom in Fifty Lines is complete" belong to the end of a preceding text; this passage then begins a new, separate text called the Kauśika Prajñāpāramitā.

- The text ends mid-title, cutting off at the colophon of the Noble Perfection of Wisdom sūtra. The Sanskrit mantra and homage formula are rendered phonetically as they appear and are not translated, which is standard practice for dhāraṇī and mantra passages. The verse near the end is a well-known citation also found in the Diamond Sūtra and the Verses on the Middle Way tradition; the rendering follows the standard doctrinal reading. The phrase "three spheres perfectly pure" refers to the Mahāyāna doctrine that the agent, object, and action of any virtuous deed are all empty of inherent existence, making the act a pure, non-referential offering.

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## Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.